

# Erasing the Line Sykes and Picot Drew

Lesson 40 — The rise of ISIS

## What you will know and be able to do

1

Trace ISIS's path from a struggling Al-Qaeda affiliate to a self-declared caliphate

2

Explain the specific symbolic significance of its rejection of colonial-era borders

3

Describe the international response and the coalition it produced

4

Evaluate why the caliphate collapsed as rapidly as it had expanded

## Two rivers of instability, converging

Lesson 36 left Al-Qaeda in Iraq weakened but not destroyed after the 2007 surge. Lesson 39 left Syria's civil war spiralling, with extremist groups exploiting the vacuum left by limited international intervention. This lesson covers what happened when both rivers of instability converged in a single, self-declared state.

## From AQI's low point to renewed relevance

Al-Qaeda in Iraq, founded by Abu Musab al-Zarqawi in 2004, faded into relative obscurity after the 2007 US troop surge severely weakened it. From 2011, exploiting Iraq's continued instability and then Syria's eruption into civil war, the group began rebuilding — rebranding itself the Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant in 2013 as it expanded directly into Syrian territory.

## Raqqa, January 2014

ISIL expelled rival rebel factions, including the Al-Qaeda-aligned Nusra Front, to take full control of Raqqa by 13 January 2014 — acquiring what would become its de facto capital months before its most dramatic expansion even began.

## February 2014: Zawahiri cuts ties

Unable to reconcile ISIL's expansion into Syria with the rival Nusra Front's own claims there, Al-Qaeda's leader Ayman al-Zawahiri formally severed all ties with the group — ISIL had grown too independent, too uncontrollable, and too extreme even for the organisation that had once been its parent.

## Mosul falls, June 2014

In a rapid June 2014 offensive, ISIL fighters overran Iraqi government defences — which in several locations simply collapsed rather than fought — capturing Mosul, Iraq's second-largest city, along with Tikrit and much of the country's north and west. At its peak, the group controlled roughly 40% of Iraqi territory.

## 29 June 2014, the first day of Ramadan

*“O Muslims in all places, rejoice, take heart, and hold your heads high!”*

ISIS spokesman Abu Muhammad al-Adnani, announcing the caliphate and Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi's leadership.



## Erasing Sykes-Picot, deliberately

The caliphate's declaration explicitly announced that “all borders and barriers among Islamic countries are now invalid” — a direct, symbolic attack on the colonial-era Sykes-Picot boundaries this entire Middle East regional study has traced back to Lesson 6. ISIS framed its own existence not merely as a new state, but as the literal undoing of the region's colonial map.

## A self-declared state, briefly functioning

**~8 million**

People living under ISIS control at its 2014 peak

**~\$1.9 billion**

Estimated annual revenue from oil, taxation, and extortion

**40%**

Share of Iraqi territory controlled at the height of the June 2014 offensive

*Unlike Al-Qaeda's decentralised network, ISIS briefly administered functioning territory — taxing, governing, and issuing its own currency plans.*

## Legitimacy through conquest, not consensus

ISIS explicitly rejected the need for religious scholarly consensus to legitimise its caliphate, arguing instead that military victory alone proved divine sanction — “we spilled rivers of our blood to water the seeds of the caliphate,” as its spokesman put it. This put the group at odds not only with the West, but with mainstream Sunni religious authority itself.

## When Iran, Saudi Arabia, and the United States agreed

ISIS's explicit declaration that Shia Muslims were not truly Muslims at all, alongside its direct territorial threat to existing states, forced an unusual, temporary alignment: Iran, Saudi Arabia, and the United States — otherwise deeply antagonistic across nearly every other issue this course has covered — each found reason to oppose ISIS militarily or diplomatically.

## December 2015: clerics respond

Thousands of Muslim clerics from across the world formally declared the caliphate illegitimate and its supporters non-Muslims — a direct challenge to ISIS's own claimed religious authority, delivered not by Western governments but by the very religious establishment ISIS claimed to represent.

## From 40% of Iraq to a handful of streets

Sustained military pressure from Iraqi forces, Syrian government troops, Kurdish-led fighters, and the US-led coalition steadily reversed ISIS's gains through 2015 and 2016, cutting its revenue by more than half. Mosul fell after an eight-month campaign, with Iraqi Prime Minister Haider al-Abadi declaring the caliphate's end on 29 June 2017 — exactly three years after its declaration.

## Destroying its own founding site

As Iraqi forces closed in, ISIS itself destroyed the Grand al-Nuri Mosque in Mosul — the very site where Baghdadi had declared the caliphate three years earlier. Prime Minister al-Abadi called the mosque's destruction “an official acknowledgement of defeat” in its own right. Raqqa fell to US-backed Syrian Democratic Forces that October; by December 2017, ISIS had lost some 95% of its territory.

## Unsustainable ambitions, or simply overwhelming force?

One explanation emphasises ISIS's inherently unrealistic goals — declaring war on nearly every other actor in the region simultaneously guaranteed eventual, overwhelming opposition. Another emphasises the sheer scale of the coalition ISIS provoked, regardless of its own strategic choices. A strong essay weighs both: the ideology's exclusionary logic help explain why so broad a coalition formed against it so quickly.



## A full essay attempt

*'ISIS's explicit rejection of Sykes-Picot borders was more significant symbolically than territorially, given how quickly the caliphate itself collapsed.' To what extent do you agree?*

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence: the territorial statistics, the border-rejection declaration, and the caliphate's collapse
- Address the counter-argument that eight million people living under its actual governance was significant in its own right

## Key terms from today

### Caliphate

A state claiming religious and political authority over all Muslims worldwide.

### Salafi-jihadism

ISIS's strict, exclusionary ideological interpretation of Sunni Islam.

### Sykes-Picot

The colonial-era agreement drawing the modern Middle East's borders, which ISIS explicitly rejected.

### Coalition of rivals

The unusual, temporary alignment of otherwise antagonistic states against a common threat.

## What to remember

ISIS emerged from Al-Qaeda in Iraq's near-collapse to briefly govern territory home to 8 million people, declaring a caliphate that explicitly rejected the region's colonial-era borders — before an unusual coalition of rivals, and its own exclusionary extremism, produced its rapid territorial collapse within three years.

## Lesson 41 — Closing Block B7: essay practice

Next lesson closes both this block and our entire Middle East regional study with focused essay practice across the Arab Spring's full arc — before Block C turns to African independence movements.